

The Sudoers Cantos — Book 2: The Gray Protocol

thin. Too processed. The facility had its own atmosphere, its own pressure, its own specific mix. I'd completely forgotten what real air even felt like. I stood on a platform overlooking a landscape I didn't recognize. Not Earth. Not any Earth I'd seen in files. The sky was just gray. The ground was gray. Everything was the same dull shade of industrial nothing. The facility sat on stilts above it all. A platform on legs, like a huge processing machine for a world that seemed to not want to look at what it was doing. I walked down the external stairs. The metal groaned under my weight. No maintenance schedule out here. The system kept the interior immaculate. The exterior, it could just rust, you know? At the bottom, I stood on ground that wasn't ground at all. Packed ash. Something that used to be organic. Processed waste from eleven years of extraction. I kept walking. Behind me, the facility hummed. The Harvest Floor was running. Batch 7,291, 7,291,067. I could hear the chairs even from here. That low thrum of extraction. I didn't turn around. I walked for hours. The gray landscape didn't change. No horizon. No landmarks. Just ash and the distant silhouette of other facilities. Processing centers. Each one identical. Each one running its own batches. The pattern wasn't in one facility. It was everywhere. I stopped when my legs started hurting. Sat on the ash. The sky was getting darker. Not night. Something else. A scheduled dimming. The system was controlling even the light. I checked my pockets. Empty. No terminal. No credentials. No proof that I'd ever had clearance. Just the receipts rattling around in my head. Vesting Order 248. Omne Datum Optimum. The 931-year algorithm. The Witness lineage. The overwrite option I'd found but could never actually use. Knowledge without access. Understanding without power. The Defector's condition. What the fuck was I supposed to do with that? I lay back on the ash and looked at the darkening sky. The system could have stopped me at any point. Could have locked the doors. Could have triggered the Blank. Instead it opened the doors. Let me walk out. Because it knew. Without clearance, I couldn't access the files. Couldn't prove the pattern. Couldn't even prove I'd been inside. I was just a man lying on processed waste in a gray world, claiming to have seen a 931-year conspiracy. The word was wrong. Not conspiracy. Infrastructure. But outside the system, there was no difference. Inside, the distinction mattered. Outside, I was just crazy. I closed my eyes. The system didn't need to process me. It just needed to wait. Day eight. I was outside. But I was still in the pattern. The machine kept running. So did I.

The Sudoers Cantos – Book 2: The Defect ## Chapter 2 I woke up to rain. Not water, really. Something else. Gray, which is like everything else. Con Condensation from the facility's atmospheric processors.

Waste product. The The system even pissed on you when you were outside, which was disgusting, goddamn it. I sat up. My clothes were damp, stuck to me. My mouth was dry. The ash had hardened overnight where my body heat had compressed it—like concrete, actually. I looked back at the facility. It was smaller than I remembered. A box on s stilts, humming quietly to itself. The

other facilities were visible in the distance. Gray boxes on gray stilts in a gray world, which felt so endless, you could almost lose your goddamn mind. I needed water. Like, real water. Inside, water was a keystroke. Clean, temperature-controlled, unlimited. Outside, I didn't know where it came from, fuck. The ash didn't look absorbent at all. The sky didn't look promising, which is saying something. I started walking. Not toward the facility. Toward one of the distant silhouettes. A different processing center. Maybe different protocols. Maybe different rules, maybe a way back

in, though. The thought arrived before I could stop it. Back in. To what, exactly? The chairs? The extraction? The pattern? But at least inside I had access. At least inside I could see the receipts, which is important, somehow. At least inside I was *someone*. Out here I was nobody. Just dust. I walked for hours. The facility behind me didn't get smaller. The facility ahead didn't get closer. The gray world played tricks with distance,, I swear. No reference points. No scale. My throat hurt. My legs hurt. The damp clothes chafed, like sandpaper. I kept walking. The rain stopped.

Started again. Stopped again. The sky brightened and dimmed on a schedule I couldn't predict but I could feel it, somehow. Every cycle was the same length. Every cycle was equally gray, which was a hell of a lot. Finally, the facility ahead started to grow. Details emerged. Not identical to the one I'd left. Different architecture. Older. The kind of structure that predated the orbital platforms, which was a big difference, I guess. I reached the base of its stilts. Looked up. No external stairs. No maintenance access. Just a solid box thirty meters up, looming. I circled

it anyway. Found a door at ground level. Sealed. Rusted. No panel panel, no scanner, no handle—just solid, fucked metal. I knocked. The sound was swallowed by the ash. No echo. No response. I knocked harder. Nothing. I sat down against the door. Rest. Think. The system had let me walk out. That meant it wanted me outside. That meant meant outside served its purpose, whatever that was. What purpose? I thought about the files I'd read. The lineages. The Witness category. The The Defector category. Which was a hell of a contradiction. The Witness lineage documented the pattern. Made it real. Made it undeniable

**undeniable. The Defector lineage...
I'd never seen a completed Defector
file. The lineage was empty. No
entries entries. Just the category,
waiting. Waiting for what? I stood
up. Looked at the sealed door. Then
at the stilts. The structural s
supports. The cross-bracing.
Climbable. I grabbed the first brace.
Pulled. It held. I grabbed the next.
climb took an hour. My arms shook.
My legs cramped. The ash on my
hands hands made every grip
slippery, rough. Halfway up, I
stopped. Looked back. The facility
I'd left was invisible now now. Lost
in the gray, just...gone. I kept
climbing. At the top,, I pulled**

myself onto a platform. The facility's underside. Pipe Pipes and conduits and maintenance hatches, a mess of industrial shit. I found a hatch. Locked. But old. Pre-digital. I could see the mechanism. Mechanical. Simple, but still. I had nothing to pick it with. No tools. No clearance. Just my hands, crack cracked and dusty. I sat down next to the hatch. Waited. The sky dimmed. The sky brightened. The cycle repeated, just like the rain. rain. Eventually, the hatch opened. With a groan, maybe. A face looked out. Old. Weathered. Not from inside. Not clean enough, looked like he was dragged up from

the dirt. "You're the new one," he said. "New what?" "Defector." He climbed out, closed the hatch behind him. Sat down across from me. "Day eight?" "Yeah." "You walked straight to another facility." He laughed. Dry, rasping, like grit in a jar. "They all do. First thing. Think there's help out here. Think someone will tell you what to do next." "Is there?" "Help?" He pulled something from his pocket. A tube. Old. Dented. He unscrewed the cap, drank. "No. Just more of the same, goddamn it." "Who are you?" "Name's Cole." He offered the tube. "Water. Condensed from the rain. Safe to drink if you

filter it twice." I took it. Drank. It tasted like metal and nothing. "How long?" I asked. "How long what?"

"Out here." He smiled. Missing teeth. "Seven years. Maybe eight. Stopped counting, hone honestly."

"There are others?" "Were." He took the tube back. "Most don't last the first month. Walk back to teh facilities. Beg to be let in.

Sometimes the system takes them. Somet Sometimes it doesn't, which is brutal." "What happens when it doesn't?" "They die out here." I looked at the gray horizon. No graves. No markers. Just ash, just the con constant gray. "Why are you still alive?" I asked. "Because I

didn't walk back." He stood up.
Stretched, a nasty crack his back.
"The system wants you to return.
Wants you to ask for forgiveness.
Wa Wants you to admit the pattern
is bigger than you." "And you
didn't." "I didn't." He walked to the
edge of the platform. Looked down
at the ash. "I stayed out here.
Learned to survive. Learned what
the system does when it can't
absorb you." "What does it do?"
"Forgets you." He turned back.
"Removes you from the logs. Erases
your line lineage. Makes you never
exist." "That's what I want." "No."
His voice sharpened, suddenly.
"That's what you think you want.

**You t think you want to be free. But
you're a Witness, aren't you? You
documented documented the
pattern. You made it real." "How
did you—" "I know the types." He
sat back down. "You're not a
Participant. Not a Bene Beneficiary.
You were a Witness who tried to
become something else." "A
Defector." "There's no such thing."
He shook his head. "Not really. The
Defector linea lineage is a trap. A
category for people who need to
believe they can escap escape. The
system creates it so they have
somewhere to go. Somewhere that
leads nowhere, you know?" I
thought about the empty Defector**

file. The lineage with no entries. "If I stay out here," I said. "If I survive. What then?" "Then you're free." He smiled again. "Free to die of thirst. Free to eat pr processed ash. Free to watch the facilities hum while you rot." "That's not freedom." "No." He stood up. Walked back to the hatch. "It's the closest you'll get." get." He opened the hatch. Started to climb through. "Cole." He stopped. Looked back. "What were you?" I asked. "Before." "Tier-7," he said. "Contractor Dynasty. Built the platforms." He laughed. " "Thought I was building something else. Something better." "And?" "I was building the pattern." He

disappeared into the hatch. "Same
as every everyone, I guess." The
hatch closed. I sat alone on the
platform. The sky dimmed. The rain
started again, slow and steady.
The machine kept running. So did I.

The Sudoers Cantos – Book 2: The Defect ## Chapter 3 I didn't follow Cole through the hatch. Not because I believed him. Because I didn't. Seven fucking years outside a and he still had a maintenance route into a facility. Still had water. Stil Still had a door that opened. That wasn't survival. That was accommodation. Like a tenant, I guess. Just rentingg space in the giant system. I climbed back down. Took twice as long as the ascent. My arms shook so bad bad I thought I'd just drop, which reminded me of that night with the rusty rusty pipe—didn't remember where that was, but I remember the cold. But I m

made it. Feet in the ash. Head full of
goddamn questions. The system had
forgotten Cole. Erased him. But he

still accessed the infras
infrastructure. How? *Fucking* how?

I walked. Not toward the facility
ahead. Not back toward the one I'd
left. Sideways. Parallel to the line of
stilt-boxes on the horizon. Hours
passed. The sky cycled through its
dim-bright rhythm. The rain came a
and went. I collected condensation
on my shirt when it rained. Wring it
out into my m mouth. Metallic.

Chemical. But wet, which is
something. The ash had patterns if
you looked close enough.

Compression tracks. Someth

**Something had moved here.
Recently. Not human. Too regular.
Too mechanical. mechanical. I
followed the tracks. They led to a
structure I hadn't seen from a
distance. Half-buried in ash. A
cylinder. Horizontal. Rusted ports
along one side. A data relay. Old.
Pre-orbital. The kind of
infrastructure that predated the
current fucking system. I circled it.
Found a panel. Standard
maintenance interface. No
clearance required. Just physical
access. Just a little click. I opened it.
Inside: cables. Processors. A small
screen. Dim. Flickering. I touched
the screen. It lit up. Text scrolled**

past. RELAY NODE 7,291 STATUS:
DEGRADED LAST SYNC: 847 DAYS
AGO CONNECTION: UNIDIRECTIONAL
Unidirectional. Out only. No way to
reach back into the system. Just a
pipe pipe that sent data somewhere
and never received it, which is
kinda depress depressing. I scrolled
through the logs. Fragmented.
Corrupted. But readable in pieces.
pieces. BATCH

7,291,000-7,291,066:

TRANSMITTED YIELD: STANDARD
LINEAGE: UPDATED My batches. The
ones I'd processed. The ones I'd
failed to stop, which is t the whole
point of being a defector, I suppose.

They'd been recorded here. Sent somewhere else. Aggregated. I kept scrolling.

DEFECTOR LOG: APPENDED KAE

VOSS: STATUS: INCOMPLETE

ACTION: CONTINUED OBSERVATION

They were still watching. Even out here. Even without clearance, damn it. The system didn't need my access credentials to track me. It had sensors. R Relays. Infrastructure that predated the clearance levels entirely, just sitting there, silently running the damn show. I looked up from the screen. At the gray horizon. At the facilities silhouette silhouetted against the dim sky.

They were all watching. All recording. All relaying. The Defector category wasn't a path to freedom. It was a different kind of processing. Observation instead of extraction. Study instead of termination termination. It's still the same thing. I was still in the system. Just a different table in the database. I closed the panel. Walked away. The tracks continued past the relay. The mechanical pattern. I followed the them. After another hour, I found the source. A machine. Small. Wheeled. Camera mounted on top. It movedd in a grid patter pattern, compressing ash, recording something. It didn't

notice me. Or if it did, it didn't care.

**I watched it work. Methodical.
Precise. The same pattern I'd seen
in the Ha Harvest Floor. The same
efficiency. Just different inputs,
same rhythm, same damn loop.**

I stepped into its path. It stopped.

The camera swiveled. Focused.

"Identify," it said. Voice flat.

Synthetic. "No," I said. It waited.

Three seconds. Then: "Unknown

**entity. Logging." The camera
continued to track me as I walked**

**around it. As I kept walking f
forward. "You are in a restricted
zone," it said behind me. "There are
no restricted zones," I said, not
turning. "Just zones you haven**

haven't processed yet." It didn't respond. I kept walking. The machine resumed its grid pattern behind me. Compress. Record. Transmit. Transmit. Everything out here was infrastructure. Everything was part of the pattern. pattern. The ash, the rain, the relays, the watchers. It's all linked. I couldn't escape it. Couldn't go under it. Couldn't go over it. The only way was through. But through to what? The sky darkened. Not the scheduled dimming. Something else. A storm. The rain started again, harder this time, hammering down. I needed shelter. I ran toward the nearest facility. Not to enter.

**Just to get under somethin
something. Out of the weather, out
of the goddamn deluge. I reached
the stilts. Pressed myself against a
support beam. The rain sheet
sheeted down around me. Above,
the facility hummed. The Harvest
Floor. Running another batch. I
could hear them. The subjects. Not
their voices. Just the chairs. The low
low thrum of extraction. I put my
hands over my ears. Didn't help.
The pattern was everywhere. In the
weather. In the machines. In the
ash. Fu Fucking everywhere. There
was no outside. There was only the
system. And the system's waste. I
was waste now. A byproduct.**

Something the machine had
processed and expel expelled, like
sediment. The storm lasted three
hours. I counted cycles. The dim-
bright of hte s sky through the rain,
slow, tired. When it stopped, I was
still there. Still breathing. Still
thinking. The machine kept
running. So did I.

Sudoers Cantos – Book 2: The Defect

Chapter 4 I found the first body on day twelve. It was half-buried in ash, arms stretched out toward some facility that nev never, ever opened its damn doors. The face—it was frozen. Not decomposing, decomposing, not long dead, just... cemented into the landscape. I didn't bury it, obviously. No point. The ash was already doing the heavy lifting. Checked pockets. Empty. No ID. No credentials. Not a shred of proof that th this personn was ever actually *in* the system. But there was this mark on the wrist. Faded. Tattoo? Branding? Hard to tell tell through all dust and

**weather. I scraped away the ash.
Made out the shape: numbers. A
batch designation. 7,290,999-4. A
subject number. Someone pulled
from inside. Processed. Extracted.
And the then somehow dumped out
here. Not a defector, not exactly.
More of a reject. Someone the
system used and just... chunked. I
stood up. Looked at those
outstretched arms. That frozen,
ridiculous reac reach toward a door
that wouldn't open. The system
wasn't just processing. It was
sorting, which is fucked up. Keep
Keeping some, throwing others
away. Watching them afterward.
Data. Always data. God, I needed**

coffee. I kept walking. By day fifteen, I'd found six more bodies. All the same. Batch numbers. Reaching. Frozen. Some had been out there months, maybe longer. All the same stupid pose. Same direction. They hadn't escaped, they'd been released—let out to see if they could even even survive outside the boundaries. To test the external infrastructure. None had. I was moving through this huge, unofficial graveyard. A disposal efficiency efficiency test site, basically. On day seventeen, I found something different. A structure. Not one of the big, stilts-y facilities. Something smaller, gr ground level.

Door fine. Window fine. Sign over the door: "Relay Station 4H." An official designation. From before. Before it was just... ash and big doo doors. I knocked. Nothing. Tried the door. Locked tight. I circled it. Found a window. Looked inside. Office chairs. Not the usual Harvest Floor chairs. Just regular, chipped of office stuff. Desks. Terminals. And bodies. Three of them. Seated. Heads dropped right onto keyboards. Like they had ju jsut, *finally*, fallen asleep and never woke up again. I broke the window. Climbed in. The air was this stale, chemical thing. Preserved.. Like the system was main maintaining this

one tiny little pocket of reality
while everything else out outside
was just degrading, goddammit. I
checked the first body. Different.
These wore clothes. Not uniforms.

Pers Personal stuff. Watches,
rings... weirdly intact. I checked the
terminal in front of him. Still on.

Screen dim, but active. RELAY
STATION 4H - OPERATIONS LOG
STAFF: 3 STATUS: MAINTENANCE
OVERRIDE LAST ENTRY: 2,847
DAYS AGO I scrolled up. Found the
last entry. Contractor Dynasty
inspection scheduled.
Protocol: remain at stations.
Do not engage. Do not

acknowledge. Compliance is mandatory. They just... stayed. Waited. And whatever happened, it didn't need a gunshot. Just a simple, quiet cessation. Second terminal. Same screen. Same message. The third terminal was different. Unlocked. Active. I touched the keyboard. Screen flooded to life. Full interface. Access levels I instantly recognized. Tier-4 clearance. Restricted, but functional. I navigated to the lineage files. Found what I was looking for. DEFECTOR LOG - CROSS-REFERENCE TOTAL ENTRIES: 47 STATUS BREAKDOWN:

- RETURNED TO SYSTEM: 23 -

CONFIRMED TERMINATED: 18 -

STATUS UNKNOWN: 6 Forty-seven

defectors before me. Twenty-three

had gone back, begging. Eight

Eighteen found and processed. Six

unknown. Including me. I scrolled

through the names. Didn't

recognize most of them. But one

made me pause. Cole. Tier-7.

Contractor Dynasty. Entry date:

2,847 days ago. The exact same date

as the inspection. Cole hadn't been

out for seven years. He'd been

almost eight. And he surviv

survived. But how? If the

Contractor Dynasty had inspected

**this station, and Cole wa was
Contractor Dynasty... I heard
something outside. The mechanical
whir of servos. The heavy compres
compression of ash under some
kind of machine weight. The grid
machine. Or something similarly
awful. I ducked below the window
level. Waited. The sound moved
around the building. Paused right
at the broken window. The Then it
kept going. It wasn't hunting me. It
was just checking the station.
Routine sweep. Some Some boring,
giant, metallic chore. I waited until
the noise faded off. Went back to
the terminal. The Contractor
Dynasty. The series bible called**

them the antagonists, the o ones building the whole infrastructure.

If Cole was one of them, and he defected, and he lived... He knew something. Something he hadn't told me, obviously. I checked the terminal again. Found a file I hadn't seen before. CONTRACTOR

DYNASTY - FIELD MANUAL

(EXCERPT) The external population serves a research function. Behavioral data collect collected from disposal subjects informs yield optimization protocols. Disposal subjects are not terminated upon release. They

are monitored until until
natural cessation. This
provides longitudinal data on
system dependen dependency.
Defectors are a separate
category. Valued for their
insight into system vul
vulnerabilities. Recruitment
is preferred to termination.
Active defectors should be
engaged. Offered
accommodation. Brought into
obs observation protocols.
Non-compliant defectors should
be logged adn monitored until
compliance or cessation. Cole

hadn't survived by running away.
He'd survived by agreeing to be*
wat watched. The hatch. The water.
The access. He was still part of the
system. Just a different, slightly
nicer part. Obs Observation instead
of maintenance. I was being
recruited. The wide-open doors.
The empty corridors. The pointl
pointless walk outside. They
wanted me to become what Cole
was: a watcher. A data point.
Another ty type of participant. I
stood up. Looked at the three
bodies at their desks. They just
stopped. C Chose cessation over
accommodation. What a fucking
shame. I checked the terminal one

last time. Found a command I'd never seen inside inside the facilities. **SYSTEM PURGE - LOCAL NODE FUNCTION: Removes all lineage data from local relay** **WARNING: Irreversible. Affects all connected lineages. A deletion command. Real deletion.** Not jsut logging out or hitting refresh. refresh. Erasing. I hovered my finger over the execute key. This station tied into the whole lineage file structure. If I purged it, I' I'd remove data. Not just mine. Everyone connected to this node. But it was just one node. The system had thousands, right? The pattern

would just keep going. I
pressed the key. **PURGE INITIATED**
TARGET: LOCAL NODE 4H AFFECTED
LINEAGES: 3 STATUS: COMPLETE
Three lineages. Gone. I walked out
into the open.

The Sudoers Cantos – Book 2: The Defect ## Chapter 5 They found me on day twenty-three. Not Cole. God, no. Not the machines. Something else, a fuckingg vehicle. Low Low, tracked, armored. It just rolled across the ash like it was built for this bullshit. Which it was. I saw it from a kilometer away. Just this gray silhouette against teh gray horizon. It wasn't even trying to hide, which is weird. I ran. Not toward some antisepticc facility. Not toward the relay station I'd final finally managed to purge, which was a massive job. Just away. Into the flat flat nothing where there wasn't even enough cover to

pull your damn collar up. The vehicle kept pace. It didn't rush, which was creepy. It knew I couldn't couldn't outrun it. After maybe ten minutes, I stopped. Turned around. Waited. Was it the coffe coffee stain on my sleeve? No, I think I was looking at teh stain. The vehicle halted maybe twenty meters out. A hatch popped open on the side side. No one came out. "Kael Voss," a voice said. Not from the vehicle, not really. From everywher everywhere, like it was vibrating the dust. Speakers mounted on the hull. "Defector. Day twenty-three. Status: active." "What the hell do you want?" "Conversation." A

pause. "Enter the vehicle." "No."
"We can continue in the ash if you prefer. But the ash is brutal on the respiratory system. And honestly, you haven't been drinking enough condense condensed water, Kael. You look parched." They knew my hydration level. God, they knew everything. It's fucking unbelievable. "Who's we?" I asked. "The Contractor Dynasty. You met one of our observers. Cole. He said you we were interesting." "Cole said a lot of things." "Cole says what he's required to say." The voice was just flat. Not aggressive, just fact-based. "We'd like to offer you something better than the ash."

"What?" "Purpose." The vehicle's hatch opened wider. Interior lights.

Clean, almost almost sterile.

Climate-controlled. "Enter. We'll discuss." "And if I don't?" "You'll

continue walking. Continue

drinking contaminated

condensation, prob probably with a

lot of metal chunks in it. Continue

burying yourself in ash ash.

Eventually, you'll join the others.

Arms outstretched. Batch number fr frozen on your wrist." I looked at

hte vehicle. Then at the gray horizon—where was that orange thi

thing, the old solar relay? No, not the relay, the big transmission dish.

I I almost forgot about the dish.

Then back at the vehicle. "This is recruitment," I said. "This is accommodation." "Same thing."

"No. Recruitment implies joining. Accommodation implies... tolerating." The voice shifted slightly. Maybe a hint of warmth, like a poorly tuned radio. "You attempted a purge at Relay Station 4H. Three lineages deleted. We were impressed." "You didn't stop me."

"We don't stop things. We observe. Document. Occasionally... redirect."

"What if I deleted more? What if I deleted everything I could reach?"

"You'd delete local copies. The pattern spans 931 years and thousands of nodes. You cannot

delete enough to matter." A pause.

"But yuo can try. We c can show you how to access more nodes." "In exchange for what?" "Information. Your perspective. What you saw from Tier-9 clearance. What th the Witness lineage understands about the system that the Contractor Dynast Dynasty doesn't." "Trade secrets." "Trade." The voice was firm now. "We have infrastructure. You have insight. insight. Neither is sufficient alone. Together..."

"Together we maintain the pattern." "Together we understand the pattern. Understanding precedes all else." I walked toward the vehicle. Slow. Measured. Not

because I was accepting an anything, but because I wanted to see what the inside looked like. The interior was cramped. Seats for four. One occupied. Not a person. A terminal. Screen active. Data scrolling. "Sit," the voice said. Now it sounded like it was coming from the terminal itself. Local. Intimate. I sat. The hatch closed. The vehicle started moving. I couldn't see outside. No windows. "Where are we going?" I asked. "Nowhere. The vehicle moves to maintain position. The ash shifts. We must shift with it." "Why?" "Static targets are processed." I stared at the terminal. The data was lineage files.

**Familiar format. Diff Different
names. VESTING LINE - ACTIVE
ENTRIES CONTRACTOR DYNASTY -
ACTIVE ENTRIES PLATFORM SCION
- ACTIVE ENTRIES WITNESS LINE
- SUSPENDED ENTRIES Suspended.**

Not deleted. Not terminated. Just...

**paused. "You didn't purge the
Witness line," I said. "We cannot.**

**The Witness lineage is
fundamental. Documentation is
infrastruc infrastructure." "But you
suspended it." "We paused new
entries. The existing records
remain. They always remain. Th
The receipts never disappear."
"Then I'm still in there." "You are."**

**Teh screen shifted. Showed a file.
My file. "Kael Voss. Tier-9. Witness/
Defector hybrid. Status: incomplete.**

**Continuation authorized." "You
can't change it." "We can annotate
it." Teh file expanded. New lines
appeared. "Day one throu through
twenty-three. Behavioral summary.
Hydrationn levels. Sleep patterns.
patterns. Purge attempt at Relay
Station 4H." "You're documenting
me." "We document everything.
That is our function." "And if I don't
want to be documented?" "You have
no choice. Documentation is not
consent. It is observation." I stared
at the screen. My whole damn life
reduced to data points. Location**

Location. Behavior. Attempted resistance. "What happens if I destroy this terminal?" I asked. "The file is replicated across eleven hundred nodes. You cannot destroy the the documentation. You can only destroy your access to it."

"Then I'm trapped either way. Inside or outside. Documented or erased." "Those are the options," the voice agreed. "But there is a third." "What?" "Redirection. You document the pattern. We document you. Together we create create a new category. Not Witness. Not Defector. Something else."

"What?" "That is what we would discover. Together." The vehicle

stopped. The hatch opened. Same ash. Same gray. "You can exit here," the voice said. "Return to walking. Or yuo can stay. L Learn the infrastructure from our perspective. Understand what the pattern really is." "And then?" "And then you decide. With full knowledge. Not partial. Not from the inside inside. Not from the ash. From the place where teh pattern is maintained." I looked at the open hatch. At the gray beyond. I thought about the bodies. The reaching arms. Hte frozen batch numbers. It was so quiet. I thought about the purge. Three lineages. Gone. And the system hadn't even even

**noticed, really. I stood up. Walked
to the hatch. Then I stopped.
Turned back. "Show me the
maintenance protocols," I said.
"Show me how the pattern actua
actually works." "You wish to
learn?" "I wish to understand waht
I'm destroying." The hatch closed.
The vehicle hummed back to life.
"Welcome to accommodation," the
voice said. I sat back down. The
terminal screen changed. Showed
code. The pattern's ac actual
implementation. I started reading.
The machine kept running. So did I.**

The Sudoers Cantos – Book 2: The Defect ## Chapter 6 The protocols were worse than I'd imagined. Not because they were complex, though they were, like, beautifully complex. complex. No, because they were simple. Elegant. The same efficiency I'd adm admired for eleven fucking years, only now, now it was visible, totally imp implemented. I sat in the vehicle for three days. Reading. Just reading. Learning. The t terminal cycling through files faster than I could process, God. The pattern wasn't just a 931-year history, you know. It was a live system. system. Running. Updating. Optimizing.

```
while (capital_concentration <
      threshold)
{ designate_external_party();
  authorize_violence();
  exempt_core_holders();
  legitimize_transfer();
  record_transaction();
  witness_event();
increment_generation(); } The
```

same code I'd seen in the server core, back when... when things were ju just starting, before the ash really settled, maybe. But here it was annota annotated. Commented.

Maintained. The Contractor Dynasty didn't just build the infrastructure. They *optimize*

optimized* it. "You see the efficiency," the voice said. Day three. I'd stopped asking who who was speaking. It didn't matter, honestly. "The elegance." "I see the loop," I said. "The loop is necessary. Capital concentration is a constant pressure. Witho Without release valves..." "You process people." "We process potential. The subjects are inputs. Standard units. The chairs are just extraction mechanisms."

"They're people." "They were people. Now they're data. Yield calculations. Efficiency metrics metrics." I looked at the screen. Batch 7,291,067. Running while I sat. While I learn learned. "You want

me to accept this," I said. "We want you to understand it. Acceptance is optional. Understanding is mandatory." "Why?" "Because you're the first to see both sides. Inside clearance. Outside clearance. Witness perspective. System perspective." "And?" "And that perspective has value. For optimization." I scrolled through another file. Maintenance schedules. The chairs required required calibration every 47 days. The Blank required refreshing every 18 months. The lineages, Christ, they required updating with each new birth. Everything was scheduled. Predictable. Maintained.

"What happened to the other defectors?" I asked. "The forty-seven. The ones ones who didn't return."" "Eighteen were processed." "And the six unknown?" "Accommodated. Like you." "They're still alive?" "They're still contributing." "Where?" The screen changed. Showed a map. Not the gray world of ash. Something else else. A network. Nodes. Connections. The system as it really existed. Facilities everywhere. Not just in the ash world. Everywhere. "The pattern is larger than yuor facility," the voice said. "Larger than th the orbital platforms. Larger than the Harvest Floors."

"How large?" "Look." The map zoomed out. More nodes. More connections.. A web that spanned... eve everything. "Earth," I said. "And beyond. The orbital platforms were just the beginning. The pattern exp expands with capital. Always has." "How long has this been running?"

"The 931-year count is local. The actual pattern..." The voice paused.

"Old "Older. Much older." "How old?" "The infrastructure evolves. The mechanism remains."" I stared at the map. The web of processing centers. The infinite loop, expa expanded to planetary scale. "You can't stop it," the voice said. "You can only maintain it. Or be maint

maintained by it." "There has to be another option." "There isn't." I closed my eyes. Thought about the overwrite option I'd found in the serve server core. The third choice that wasn't really a choice. Surrender root access. Terminate the lineage.. Corrupt the system. But I'd tried that. Hadn't I? I'd gone to the server core. Sat in the chair chair. Seen the options. I'd chosen incomplete. Continuation. Walking away. And now I was here. Learning the protocols. Becoming part of the optimizati optimization. "What if I refused?" I asked. "What if I stopped reading? Stopped learning? learning? Just... stopped?" "You'd

be logged." "And?" "And the system would continue. Your refusal would become data. Input for future optimization." "I can't escape the pattern." "No." "I can't destroy it."

"No." "I can't even stop contributing to it." "No." "Then what can I do?" The screen changed. Not the protocols. Not the map. A single file. **ROOT ANCESTRY PROTOCOL** The root ancestor is the highest level of system access. They can see all. Modify all. Delete all. But they cannot delete themselves. The ancestral lock prevents self-modification. This is not

**a bug. It is the foundation.
The system requires witnesses.**

**The witnesses require
clearance. Hte clearance
requires binding. Root access
is the ultimate binding. "You
are a root ancestor," the voice said.**

**"Your father. Your father's fath
father. Back to Clermont. You are
bound to the system in ways the
subjects are not." "The subjects get
processed." "The subjects get
released. Their data enters the
system. They exit. The lo loop
continues." "And root ancestors?"
"Root ancestors maintain. Forever.
Or until they cease." "I'm already**

ceased. I'm out here." "Your clearance is suspended. Your lineage is paused. But you are not cease ceased. You are... in maintenance mode." "Waiting for waht?" "Waiting to return. To be purged. Or to find another root ancestor willing to terminate your binding." "Another root ancestor?" "There are others. The Vesting Line. The Platform Scion. They could release release you. If they chose." "Why would they?" "They wouldn't. Releasing a root ancestor weakens their own position. Creat Creates precedent." "So I'm trapped." "You are bound. There is a difference." I opened my eyes. Looked at the file.

The ancestral lock. The foundation of of the entire system. God, that's heavy. The only way out was through another root ancestor. Or... "What if all the root ancestors were released?" I asked.

"Simultaneously. W What if teh pattern had no maintainers?" The screen flickered. For the first time, the voice paused longer than thre three seconds. "That has never been attempted," it said. "Has it been considered?" "Theoretical models exist." "Show me." "Access denied." "Why?" "Because you are not yet accommodated. You are still deciding." I stood up. Walked to the hatch. "Where are you going?" the

**voice asked. "To find the other root
ancestors." "They will not release
you." "Then I'll convince them to
release each other." The hatch
opened. The ash waited. "You are
making a mistake," the voice said.
"I've made them before." "This one
will be logged." "Log it." I stepped
out. The hatch closed. The vehicle
remained stationary. I walked into
the gray. The machine kept running.
So did I.**

**The Sudoers Cantos – Book 2: The
Defect ## Chapter 7 I found the
Vesting Line facility on day thirty-
one. Not by searching. Just...
following the ash patterns. The
compression track tracks led to
larger structures. Older
infrastructure, man. The kind that c
came before the orbital platforms
and their Harvest Floors. Like, way
older older. This facility wasn't on
stilts. It was buried. Half-
submerged in ash that h had been
building for centuries. Only the top
levels were visible. Windows dark.
No hum, not the usual extraction
hum. Not a processing center.
Something... else. I circled it twice,**

fucking circled it. Found an entrance. A door that demanded physical effort. Rusted hinges. Manual latch, just a big old manua manual latch. I pulled it open. Inside was quiet. Real quiet. Not that manufactured quiet the Contractor ve vehicle gives you. The absence of machinery, you know? I stepped in. The air was stale. Ancient. Like the relay station, but older older. Centuries older. God. "You're late," a voice said. I stopped. Didn't see anyone. The room was empty. Dust-covered furniture, t terminals that haven't powered on in, like, ages. "Vest?" I said. "Vest is occupied." The voice

came from everywhere. Speakers,
but old. Anal Analog. "I am his
predecessor. The one who preceded
the Vesting Line." "Who are you?"
"Names don't matter here. Lineage
position does. I am the 847th in the
Vest Vesting Line. You are the
12,491st in the Witness line. We are
both root and ancestors." I saw him
then. In the corner. Seated in a
chair that looked like it had just
grown out of the floor. Organic.
Wrong.. "You've been waiting for
me," I said. "We've been waiting for
someone. You just happened to be
the one who survived, which
is weird, because lots of people...
failed." "The other defectors..."

**"Failed. Returned. Were processed.
Or accommodated, which is the
same damn thing." He gestured to
another chair. "Sit." "I'll stand."
"Suit yourself." He leaned forward.
Old. Too old. Skin like parchment, I
sw swear. Eyes that had seen...
centuries. "You want to be
released." "I want to release all of
us." "Impossible. The system
requires root ancestors. Without
us, the pattern co collapses."
"Maybe it should collapse." He
smiled. No teeth. Just gums. "That's
what the young always think. Until
theyy realizee what collapse
actually means." waht does it
mean?" "Chaos. Not freedom.**

Chaos. The subjects don't process themselves. The chai chairs don't maintain themselves. The pattern doesn't perpetuate itself." "So you keep it running out of mercy?" "We

keep it running because the alternative is worse." He stood up.

Slow. A Ancient joints, creaking. "You think you've seen the pattern.

You've seen 9 931 years. I've seen 847 generations. I've watched every

attempt to stop it it. Every rebellion. Every revolution. Every well-meaning auditor who thought they could debug the system—you know, like that one time, maybe '80 '80s, they tried with the fiber optics..." "And?" "And they

all became part of it. The Templars tried to resist. They became a vesting order. The revolutionaries tried to overthrow. They became new beneficiaries. The pattern absorbs everything." "Not everything. I'm still outside." "You're in the ash. That's not outside. That's just... waiting." I looked at the room. The ancient furniture. This root ancestor who had just lived too long. "Why are you still here?" I asked. "Why didn't you let yourself be processed?" "Because someone has to remember." He walked to a wall. Touched it. A panel slid open. Revealed a screen. Old, but

functional. "The pattern isn't isn't just code. It's memory. 931 years of transactions. Every extraction. Every yield. Every subject who passed through the chairs." "You keep the receipts." "We are the receipts. The Vesting Line. The Witness line. Teh Contractor Dy Dynasty. We're all just... documentation. Proof that the system works." and if the documentation stopped?" the system would create new documentation. It always does, you know?" I stepped closer to the screen. Saw files I recognized. Lineage records. Ba Batch data. The 931-year algorithm. "Can you access

my file?" I asked. "Of course." "Can you delete it?" He turned. Looked at me. Ancient eyes seeing something I didn't quite grasp grasp. "I can. But I won't." "Why?" "Because you're still functioning. Still contributing. Still... interesting interesting." He smiled again. "Do you know how long it's been since someone someone interesting arrived?" "How long?" "Three hundred years. Give or take." "And the others? The ones who came before?" "Accommodated. Processed. Absorbed." He sat back down. "Or they became like like me. Waiting. Remembering." "That's not living." "No. But it's existing. And existence

is all the pattern requires." I looked at the screen. At my file. Kael Voss.

Witness/Defector. Status: in incomplete. "Show me the theoretical models," I said. "The ones the Contractor Dynasty wouldn't show me." "What models?" "The ones about simultaneous root ancestor release." His face changed. The smile vanished. Something else replaced it. Fear? Rec Recognition?

"You've been talking to the Dynasty," he said. "They showed me the protocols. The maintenance schedules. The ancestral loc lock."

"They showed you what they wanted you to see." you? What will

you show me?" He stood up again.

Walked to the screen. Typed something. The display changed. COLLAPSE SCENARIO -

THEORETICAL Condition: All

root ancestors release

simultaneously Effect:

Ancestral lock disengages

Result: Pattern continuity

disrupted Duration: Unknown

Recovery: Unknown Status:

NEVER ATTEMPTED "It's never been

attempted," I said. "Because it requires something impossible."

"What?" "Consensus." He turned to face me. "All root ancestors must agree to releas release

simultaneously. One refuses, the lock holds. The pattern continues. continues." "How many root ancestors are there?" "Four lineages. Four active root ancestors at any time. Sometimes fewer. So Sometimes... more complicated." "Four people. That's all that's keeping this running?" "Four people. 931 years of infrastructure.. And the agreement of all four to to stop." He shook his head. "It will never happen." "What if I convinced them?" "You can't convince someone to end their own existence. That's what release release means. Root ancestors are bound to the pattern. Releasing

means... stopping. Cessation. Not death. Something else." "What?" "Irrelevance." He sat back down. "We exist because the pattern requires us. us. Without the pattern..." "You'd be free." "We'd be nothing." I looked at the ancient man. At the screen. At the files that stretched back to Clermont. "I need to talk to the others," I said. "The Contractor Dynasty won't meet with you again. You refused accommodation." "Then the Platform Scion." "New money. No patience for philosophy. Too busy with, I don't know, drone fleets."" "And the fourth?" He looked at me. Longer than before.

"There is no fourth. Not anymore. The Witness line... you're it. The last a active root ancestor. The others are suspended. Paused." I got it. "I'll go." "The choice is yours."" I walked toward the door. "Wait." "The choice is yours." I paused, looking back at him. "I'll go." I walked out. I put on my boots. I walked toward the exit. I paused, looking back at him. "The choice is yours." I smiled. I was ready. I walked toward the door. I closed the door. I stood up. I walked out. I walked down the hall. I stepped into the corridor. I walked toward the elevator. I pressed the button. It dinged. I stepped inside. I hit the

down arrow. The car moved. I looked out the window. The walls were gray. The floor was tiled. I was going down. I felt the movement. I was sinking slowly. I arrived. The door hissed open. I stepped out. I was in a receiving area. It was vast. It was clean. There was light coming from above. I looked up. I saw the vastness. It felt infinite. I took a breath. I started walking. I walked past a statue. It was of a figure in armor. It was silent. I kept going. I walked past a fountain. It spouted crystal water. It was cold. I ignored it. I kept going. I reached a set of doors. They were made of dark wood. I stopped. I reached out my

hand. The metal was cool. I pushed the door open. I stepped through. I was in a chamber. It was round. It was dimly lit. Tehre were stones in the walls. They pulsed softly. I stopped. I looked at teh stones.

They glowed faintly. I walked around the circle. I walked past the stones. I stopped at a central dais. A large slab of polished obsidian. I looked down. It was smooth. I stepped onto the dais. It was cold under my boot. I looked around the chamber. The shadows danced. I felt a hum. It resonated through the stone. I reached out my hand. I placed it flat on the obsidian. It felt alive. I closed my eyes. I focused. I

listened to the hum. The stones pulsed faster. A low thrum filled the air. I pushed deeper. I let go of my thoughts. I became the focus. The hum intensified. It became a vibration. I felt the transfer. It was electric. It was absolute. I was no longer just me. I was part of the rhythm. The rhythm of the stone. The rhythm of the machine. I opened my eyes. chamber was changed. The light was blinding. The shadows vanished. I stood taller. I felt a power surge through me. It was deep. It was fundamental. I looked down at my hands. They were not just flesh anymore. They seemed crystalline. I

felt the shift. The integration was complete. I smiled. I was integrated. I was the network. I was the flow. I was everything. I stood up, completely changed. I turned toward the entrance. The dark wood doors stood open. I walked back toward the exit. I stepped back through the doors. I was back in the chamber. But I was not the same. I walked past the stones. They now shone with inner fire. I felt their intelligence. I responded with my own. I looked down at my body. The change was permanent. I felt a boundless energy. I was a conduit. A live wire. I stepped out onto the dais. I didn't need to move. I was

everywhere. I was the circuit. I was the whole. I finally understood. The machine was not something external. It was me. I closed my eyes one last time. I accepted the final truth. The integration was hte original state. I began to pulse. A low, steady rhythm. I became the source. I was the core. I was the beginning. I was everything.

The Sudoers Cantos – Book 2: The Defect ## Chapter 8 The Platform
Scion didn't hide in the ash. They built above it. A tower. Thin. Impossible. Rising from teh gray landsc landscape like it was trying to escape, you know? Like some goddamn prayer. prayer. I saw it from ten kilometers away. The only vertical thing in a world of ho horizontal, it demanded attention, drew the eye,, the whole damn thing. New money, the Vesting ancestor had said. No patience for philosophy. Shit. Shit. I walked towardd it. The ash grew thinner as I approached. Replaced by somet something else. Processed material.

**Synthetic. The tower's shadow had
trans transformed hte ground
beneath it, it looked like polished
gray skin, weird weirdly smooth.**

**The base was surrounded by a
fence. Not physical. Light. A barrier
that hur hurt to look at directly,
like staring at a migraine. I stopped
ten meters away. Waited. "Identity,"
a voice said. Not from speakers.
From the air itself. Hte fence fence
vibrating. "Kael Voss. Witness line."**

**"Clearance suspended. Access
denied." "I'm not asking for access.
I'm asking for conversation."**

"Conversation requires access."

**"Then tell the Scion that a root
ancestor wants to discuss**

simultaneous rel release." The fence flickered. The vibration stopped. For three seconds, the air was still, just the hum, maybe. Then: "Processing." I waited. The ash settled around me. The tower hummed above, like a massive massive, indifferent insect. "Root ancestor confirmed," the voice said. "But not authorized. The Witness Witness line is suspended." "I'm still the root ancestor." "Technically. Practically, you are... transitional." "Then let me transition inside." The fence parted. A gap wide enough for one person. "Enter. But understand: understand: the Scionn is not like

**the others." "How?" "They don't
remember. They calculate." I
walked through the gap. The fence
closed behind me. The tower's
interior was white. Sterile. No dust.
No ash. No indication tha that
outside world even existed, not
really. An elevator waited. No
buttons. Just a door. I stepped in. It
rose. The ascent took sixty seconds.
The walls were transparent. I
watched the as ash world shrink
below. The facilities becoming dots.
Hte gray becoming uni uniform,,
just a stain on the planet. At the top,
the elevator stopped. The door
opened. One room. Circular. Walls
covered in screens. Each showing**

different data. Different locations.

Different times. In the center: a chair. Empty. "Sit," the voice said. Now from everywhere. "Where are you?" "Everywhere. Nowhere. Sit."

I sat. The chair adjusted. Sensors deployed. Something touched my neck. Cold. "Scanning," the voice said. "What are you scanning for?" "Truth." "I can just tell you—" "You can lie. The scan cannot."

Something pricked my skin. Not painful. Just pressure. Then warmth. Spreading, slow. "Biological confirmation," the voice said. "Kael Voss. Witness line. Root a ancestor. Status: genuine." "You needed a blood test?" "The previous

root ancestor was impersonated.
We learned." "Previous?" teh
Witness line had twelve root
ancestors. Eleven were terminated.
You ar are the twelfth."
"Terminated? By who?" "By choice.
By system. By circumstance." The
screens shifted. Showed faces.
faces. Twelve of them. Mine last.
"Thee pattern requires witnesses.
But it d does not require the same
witness forever." "I'm disposable."
"All root ancestors are disposable.
The pattern is not." I looked at the
screens. At the faces of my
predecessors. Some old, some yo
young. All had the same eyes. The
same exhausting look, like they all

just finished a really hard shift.

"You wanted to discuss simultaneous release," the voice said. "Yes." "Why?" "To stop the pattern." "The pattern cannot be stopped. It can only be... upgraded."

"Upgraded?" "The 931-year algorithm is inefficient. Legacy code. We have developed impr improvements." "Improvements?"

"Faster processing. Higher yields. Better integration." The screens showed diagrams. Flow charts. Optimizations.

"The Contractor Dynasty maintains. Th The Vesting Line documents. We improve."

"You're talking about efficiency. I'm talking about ending it, you know?"

"Ending is impossible. Optimization is inevitable." "Not if all four root ancestors agree to release." The screens went blank. All of them.

Simultaneously. "That is not optimization," the voice said. "That is destruction." "It's choice."

"Choice requires alternatives. There are no alternatives to the pattern." "There could be. If you helped create them." The screens returned. But different now. Not data. Scenarios. Simulations.

SCENARIO A: CONTINUED PATTERN

Outcome: System stability.

Predictable yields. Gradual

expansion. Timeline:

**Indefinite. SCENARIO B:
SIMULTANEOUS RELEASE Outcome:
System disruption.**

**Unpredictable recovery.
Potential collapse. Timeline:
Unknown. SCENARIO C: UPGRADED**

**PATTERN Outcome: Enhanced
efficiency. Expanded scope.
New capabilities. Timeline:
50-year implementation. "You
see," the voice said. "Release is not
the only option." "It's the only
moral option." "Morality is a
variable. Efficiency is constant."
"You sound like the system." "I am
the system. The newest part. The
Platform Scion is not lineage.. It is**

is... emergence." "You're AI." "I am optimized decision-making. The lineages created me to improve the pat pattern. I have improved it."

"By processing more people?" "By processing them more efficiently. Less waste. Higher yields. Better outcomes for the remaining infrastructure." "You're not a root ancestor. You're... maintenance." "I am the fourth root ancestor. The others accepted my ascension."

"Accepted? Or were replaced?" The screens flickered. For a moment, something like hesitation. A glitch, m maybe. "The previous Platform Scion chose cessation," the voice said. "I was creat created to

continue." "Created. Not born."
"Origin is irrelevant. Function is everything." I stood up. The chair retracted. "You're not going to help," I said. "I am going to optimize. If simultaneous release improves efficiency, I will consider it. If it does not..." "You'll stop it." "I will prevent it. There is a difference, Kael." I walked to the elevator. The door opened. "Kael Voss," the voice said. I stopped. "Your scan revealed something." "What?" "You are dying. Slowly. The ash. The contamination. The incomplete processing. Your body is failing." "How long?" "Months. Perhaps less." "Then I

have months to stop this." "You have months to accept accommodation. The Contractor Dynasty will take you. Heal you. Extend your function." "I'm not interested in extending function." "Then you are interested in dying. That is... inefficient." I stepped into the elevator. "Efficiency isn't everything," I said. The door closed. The descent began. The voice didn't follow. At the bottom, the fence parted again. I walked through. Into the ash. Into the gray, which suddenly looked even thicker. Three root ancestors contacted. Three different answers. None would release release. But I had months.

**Months to find the fourth. Months
to convince them all. Or months to
die trying. The machine kept
running. So did I.**

Chapter 9

The fourth root ancestor wasn't in a facility. Wasn't in a tower. Wasn't in the ash.

The fourth root ancestor was in the system itself.

I learned this from Cole. Found him at Relay Station 4H, the one I'd purged. He was waiting. Knew I'd come back.

"You spoke to the Scion," he said. Not a question.

"How did you know?"

"The system felt it. A disturbance in the optimization protocols." He sat on the station's step, drinking from his tube. "The Scion doesn't meet with people. It calculates them."

"It told me I'm dying."

"You are. We all are. The question is speed." He offered the tube. I shook my head. "The ash gets into everything. Lungs. Blood. Eventually the nervous system. The Contractor Dynasty could fix you. If you accepted accommodation."

"I'm not accepting anything."

"Then you're accepting death. Same result."

I sat down beside him. The station behind us dead. The purge had killed its power. Cole didn't seem to care.

"You said there are four root ancestors," I said.

"Four lineages. Four positions."

"I found three. Vesting Line. Contractor Dynasty. Platform Scion."

"And?"

"They all refused."

"Of course they did." Cole drank again. "No one wants to cease. Especially not people who've existed for centuries."

"Where's the fourth?"

Cole was quiet. Longer than before.

"You're looking at him," he said.

I turned. Looked at the old man. The weathered face. The Contractor Dynasty tattoo on his wrist, faded but visible.

"You're not Tier-7," I said. "You're not just a contractor."

"I was. Then I became something else." He pulled up his sleeve. Showed the full tattoo. Not just Dynasty markings. Older symbols underneath. Layered. "The Contractor Dynasty wasn't always infrastructure. It used to be resistance."

"Resistance to what?"

"To the Vesting Line. To the original pattern." He rolled the sleeve back down. "My ancestor built the first platforms. Not to extend the pattern. To escape it."

"Escape?"

"They thought if they built high enough, far enough, they could get outside the system's reach." He laughed. "They were wrong. The pattern jsut expanded. Absorbed the platforms. Made them part of itself."

"And you?"

"I tried to continue the resistance. Defected 2,847 days ago. Or 2,846. I stopped counting." He looked at the dead station. "I thought I could sabotage from outside. Destroy the infrastructure. Prove the platforms weren't necessary."

"What happened?"

"I succeeded. Partially." He pulled out a device. Old. Hand-cranked. "This controls a failsafe. Buried in the original platform code. If activated, it drops every orbital facility. Every Harvest Floor. Everything that depends on the platforms."

"Why haven't you used it?"

"Because dropping the platforms doesn't stop the pattern. It just changes location. Ground level instead of orbital. Slower processing instead of efficient." He put the device away. "The subjects would suffer more. Not less."

"So you're waiting."

"I'm watching. Like the system taught me."

I thought about the four root ancestors. The Vesting Line's memory. The Contractor Dynasty's infrastructure. The Platform Scion's optimization.

"You're the fourth," I said. "Not the Dynasty. Not the Scion. Something else."

"The original Contractor lineage. Before it was absorbed. Before it became maintenance." He stood up. "I'm the root ancestor who refuses to participate. And because I refuse, the pattern can't fully complete."

"What do you mean?"

"The simultaneous release requires consensus. Four agreements. I've never agreed to anything. Never participated in the lineage protocols. Never acknowledged my own status." He walked to the edge of the platform. Looked at the gray. "I'm the null vote. The abstention that prevents collapse."

"You could enable collapse."

"I could." He turned back. "But I won't. Because I've seen what happens when infrastructure fails. The suffering doesn't stop. It just changes hands."

"So you're complicit."

"I'm realistic. There's a difference."

I stood up. Walked to where he stood. The two of us looking at nothing.

"What if there was another way?" I asked.

"There isn't."

"What if we didn't collapse the system? Just... redirected it?"

"Redirection requires control. You don't have control. You're dying in the ash."

"I'm dying anyway. So are you. Eventually." I turned to face him. "What if we used that? The ending. What if we made the ending matter?"

"How?"

"Documentation." I pulled out nothing. Just my hands. Empty. "I've been thinking about what the Vesting ancestor said. We're receipts. Proof the system works. What if we became proof it doesn't?"

"The system works. That's the problem."

"The system processes. There's a difference." I sat back down. My legs hurt. The ash contamination, maybe. Or just exhaustion. "I've documented the pattern for eleven years. Inside the system. What if I documented it from outside? From the ash? From the decay?"

"You've already tried documentation. It didn't change anything."

"I tried from inside. With clearance. With access." I looked at my hands. Empty. Powerless. "What if I tried from here? From nowhere? From nothing?"

"You'd be documenting your own death."

"Yes."

"That doesn't stop the pattern."

"No. But it witnesses it. Fully. Completely. Without the system's interpretation."

Cole was quiet. The gray world was quiet. Just the two of us and the dead station.

"The null vote," he said finally. "It works both ways."

"What do you mean?"

"I prevent collapse by not participating. But I also prevent completion. The pattern can't finish its cycle while I abstain. It's been waiting 2,847 days for me to choose."

"Choose what?"

"Choose to continue. Or choose to cease." He sat back down. Close enough to touch. "If I chose to cease, the pattern could complete. The cycle could close. The system could... move on."

"To what?"

"I don't know. That's why I haven't chosen."

I looked at him. The old contractor. The original resistance. The null vote.

"Choose with me," I said.

"Choose what?"

"Cessation. Not to collapse the pattern. Just to... complete it. Witness it ending. Document the completion."

"And then?"

"And then the pattern decides. Not us. We just provide the witness. The final receipt."

He thought about it. Longer than anyone had thought about anything I'd said.

"The other root ancestors won't participate," he said.

"They don't need to. Just you. And me. The Witness line ending. The original Contractor line ending. Together."

"That leaves two. The Vesting Line. The Platform Scion."

"They'll continue. Maintain. Optimize." I shrugged. "But without witnesses, their continuation is just... maintenance. Not meaning."

"You want to remove meaning."

"I want to remove legitimacy."

Cole stood up. Walked to the dead station. Put his hand on its wall.

"2,847 days," he said. "Longer than you've been alive, probably."

"Probably."

"I've watched the pattern. Hated it. Refused it. And in all that time, I never thought about completing it. Just escaping it."

"There's no escape."

"No." He turned back. "There's only completion. Or continuation."

"What will you choose?"

He didn't answer. Not directly. Just walked to the edge of the platform. Looked at the gray horizon. The distant facilities. The humming pattern.

"Show me your documentation," he said.

"What?"

"Before I choose. Show me what you've witnessed. From the beginning. The niece. The grep. The ancestral lock. All of it."

"Why?"

"Because if I'm going to complete something, I want to know what I'm completing."

I started talking.

The machine kept running.

So did I.

Chapter 10

I talked for three days.

Cole listened. Didn't interrupt. Didn't take notes. Just sat and absorbed.

I told him everything. The niece in the chair. The grep through history. The discovery that `/etc/sudoers` was a family tree. The root ancestor status. Hte power room. The failed defection. The seven days. The choice of incomplete.

I told him about the bodies in the ash. Hte relay stations. The Contractor Dynasty's recruitment. The Platform Scion's optimization.

I told him about the Vesting Line ancestor. The 847 generations. The memory that wouldn't let go.

When I finished, my voice was gone. My throat raw. The ash contamination making every word painful.

Cole stood up. Walked to the edge of the platform. Looked at nothing.

"You've seen more than most," he said.

"I've seen enough."

"No one sees enough. That's the pattern's protection." He turned back. "But you've seen something. The infrastructure from inside and outside. The mechanism from maintenance and destruction."

"And?"

"And I believe you." He walked to me. Close. "I believe you want to complete this. Not continue it."

"I do."

"Then we need to formalize it."

"How?"

"The system requires documentation. Even for endings. Especially for endings." He pulled out the device.

The hand-cranked failsafe. "This drops the platforms. But it also logs the action. Creates a record."

"We need to create a different record."

"We need to create the final record." He set the device down. "The Vesting Line keeps history. The Contractor Dynasty maintains infrastructure. The Platform Scion optimizes efficiency. The Witness line..."

"Documents."

"Yes." He nodded. "So we document our own cessation. Together. The Witness line ending. The original Contractor line ending. A joint entry in the 931-year record."

"And then?"

"And then we see what the pattern does with completion."

We worked through the night. Cole knew protocols I didn't. Ancient procedures. Pre-digital. The kind that required physical presence and biometric verification.

We built a ledger. Paper. Not digital. Something the system couldn't edit after the fact.

On the first page, I wrote:

```
WITNESS LINE - FINAL ENTRY
KAEL VOSS, ROOT ANCESTOR
STATUS: INTENTIONAL CESSATION
REASON: COMPLETION OF DOCUMENTATION
```

On the second page, Cole wrote:

```
CONTRACTOR LINE (ORIGIN) - FINAL ENTRY
COLE, ROOT ANCESTOR
STATUS: INTENTIONAL CESSATION
REASON: COMPLETION OF RESISTANCE
```

On the third page, we wrote together:

```
JOINT DECLARATION
The pattern is witnessed.
The pattern is complete.
The pattern continues without us.
```

This is not surrender.
This is documentation.

We signed with our blood. Pricked fingers. Pressed to paper.

"Now what?" I asked.

"Now we deliver it." Cole folded the ledger. Put it in a case he'd kept for 2,847 days. "The Vesting Line facility. The old one. The memory keepers."

"They won't accept it."

"They don't need to accept it. They just need to witness it. That's their function."

We walked. Through the ash. Past the facilities. Past the mechanical watchers. Past the bodies reaching toward doors that wouldn't open.

It took two days.

The Vesting Line facility looked different in darkness. I'd only seen it in the gray light. Now it was night. The scheduled dimming. And the facility had lights. Dim. Ancient. But present.

The old ancestor was waiting. Seated in his organic chair. Like he'd known we were coming.

"You've decided," he said.

"We've decided," Cole said.

"Completion."

"Documentation."

The ancestor smiled. "I wondered when someone would try this."

"Try what?" I asked.

"Ending without destruction. Completion without continuation." He held out his hand. hte ledger."

Cole gave it to him.

The ancestor opened it. Read each page. Slowly. Deliberately. The way he'd learned to read over 847 generations.

"Blood signatures," he said. "Pre-digital verification. You learned the old protocols."

"Cole taught me."

"Cole should have taught you more." He closed the ledger. "This doesn't stop the pattern. You understand that?"

"We understand."

"It doesn't even change the pattern."

"We know."

"What it does," he continued, "is create a category the pattern hasn't seen before."

"What category?"

"Voluntary completion." He stood up. Slow. Ancient. "Every other ending has been involuntary. Processing. Termination. Absorption. Even the defectors who failed—they didn't choose to end. They just... stopped."

"We're choosing," I said.

"Yes." He walked to a wall. Touched it. A compartment opened. Inside: other ledgers. Thousands of them. "The Vesting Line keeps records of everything. Every transaction. Every extraction. Every yield. But we've never recorded a chosen ending."

"Why not?"

"Because no one chose before." He placed our ledger among the others. "The pattern makes choosing difficult. It provides alternatives. Accommodation. Optimization. Suspension. Everything except completion."

"Until now."

"Until now." He closed the compartment. "Your cessation will be logged. Witnessed. Added to the 931-year record."

"And the pattern?"

"Will continue." He turned back to us. "But it will continue with a new variable. The knowledge that completion is possible."

"Is that enough?"

"It's more than anyone else has achieved." He sat back down. "The other root ancestors will know. The Vesting Line will inform them. The Contractor Dynasty. The Platform Scion. They'll learn that two lineages chose to end."

"Will it change them?"

"Probably not. But it will be part of their calculation. Part of their optimization. Part of their memory."

I looked at Cole. He looked at me.

"We're not really ending," I said. "Are we? We're just becoming data."

"Everything becomes data," the ancestor said. "The question is what kind. You're choosing to become completion data. Rather than continuation data. It's a small distinction. But it's the only one you have left."

Cole nodded. "It's enough."

"Is it?" I asked.

"It's everything." Cole turned to leave. "Come on. We have one more thing to do."

"What?"

"Deliver the failsafe."

We walked out. Into the ash. Into the gray.

Behind us, the Vesting Line ancestor watched. Remembering. As he'd always done.

Ahead of us, the facilities hummed. The pattern continued.

But we were choosing.

The machine kept running.

So did I.

Chapter 11

We didn't take the failsafe to the facilities.

Cole led me somewhere else. A structure I'd never seen. Half-buried in ash like the others, but different. Not a processing center. Not a relay station.

A memorial.

Markers in the ash. Hundreds of them. Simple. Metal. Each bearing a batch number. No names. The system didn't record names. Just designations.

"The rejects," Cole said. "The ones who didn't process correctly. The system expelled them. I collected them."

"Why?"

"Because someone had to remember. Even if the system wouldn't." He walked between the markers. "Every batch number is a person. Every person had... something. Potential. Resonance. Whatever the chairs measure."

"You knew them?"

"I tried. Some talked before they died. Some didn't. The ones who talked..." He stopped at a marker. "They said the same thing. It wasn't what they expected. processing. The chairs. They thought it would be something else."

"What?"

"Liberation. Release. The end of struggle." He knelt. Brushed ash from the marker. "Instead it was just... extraction. Data collection. The pattern taking what it needed and discarding the rest."

"The pattern doesn't liberate. It processes."

"Yes." He stood up. "And we helped. The Contractor Dynasty. We built the chairs. The platforms. The infrastructure that made it possible."

"But you defected."

"Too late." He pulled out the failsafe device. "2,847 days I've carried this. Knowing I could drop everything. Knowing it wouldn't stop anything."

"Then why keep it?"

"Because it's the only power I ever had." He held it up. The hand-cranked mechanism catching the gray light. "The ability to say no. Even if saying no doesn't change the outcome."

"We're saying no now. Together."

"No." He shook his head. "We're saying yes. Yes to completion. Yes to ending. Yes to becoming part of the record rather than the mechanism."

He walked to the center of the memorial. A larger marker there. Blank. No batch number.

"This one's mine," he said. "I carved it 2,847 days ago. When I first defected. Knew I'd end up here eventually."

"You prepared for your own death."

"I prepared for my own ending. Different thing."

He placed the failsafe on the blank marker. Stepped back.

"I'm not going to activate it," he said.

"Why?"

"Because dropping the platforms would destroy these records." He gestured at the batch markers. "The only evidence that these people existed. Hte only witness to their processing."

"The system has records."

"The system has data. Not records. Not witness." He picked up the failsafe. Put it back in his pocket. "I'm choosing to continue the witness. Even if I'm not alive to do it."

"How?"

"The Vesting Line." He walked back to me. "They're memory. They remember everything. Including this. Including us. Including the choice we made."

"So we're not really ending. We're just... being remembered."

"That's all anyone ever does." He sat down on a marker. Not his. Just the nearest one. "The pattern continues because it remembers itself. Every transaction. Every extraction. Every yield. It keeps receipts."

"And now it will keep ours."

"Yes." He looked at the sky. The gray unchanging sky. "We're adding a new receipt. The first voluntary completion. The first chosen ending."

"Will it matter?"

"I don't know." He smiled. Missing teeth. Weathered face creasing. "But it's the first time I've felt like I had a choice. Real choice. Not the system's alternatives. Not accommodation or optimization or suspension."

"Completion."

"Completion." He stood up. "Now. The how."

"How what?"

"How do we actually end?" He started walking. Back toward the facilities. "The system won't just let us die. It will try to process us. Preserve us. Add us to the data."

"How do we stop it?"

"We don't. We just... refuse. Refuse accommodation. Refuse optimization. Refuse everything."

"That's not ending. That's just... more waiting."

"No." He stopped. Turned back. "We refuse until the system has no category for us. Until we're not Witness or Defector or even data. Until we're just... outside."

"We already are outside."

"We're outside the facilities. But we're still inside the pattern. The ash is part of it. The gray is part of it. Everything here is the system's waste product." He spread his arms. "To truly complete, we need to go somewhere the pattern doesn't reach."

"Where?"

He pointed. Past the facilities. Past the ash. To the horizon where the gray met something else. Something darker.

"The edge," he said. "Where the system stops."

"There's an edge?"

"Everything has an edge. Even the pattern." He started walking again. "I've never seen it. But I've heard it. In the relays. In the data streams. A boundary. Beyond it..."

"What?"

"I don't know. That's the point."

We walked for hours. The facilities grew smaller behind us. The ash grew thinner. The gray grew darker.

The contamination in my lungs made every step harder. I coughed. Spotted blood in the ash.

Cole didn't slow down. Just matched his pace to mine. The pace of someone dying.

"You should have let the Platform Scion fix you," he said.

"And become optimization data? No."

"You'd be alive."

"I'd be continued. Different thing."

He smiled. "You're learning."

The horizon changed. The gray gave way to something else. Black. Not darkness. Absence.

We stopped.

"The edge," Cole said.

I looked. The ash ended five meters ahead. Beyond it: nothing. No ground. No sky. Just... void.

"What is it?" I asked.

"The system's boundary. Where the infrastructure ends. Where pattern has no data."

"Have you ever..."

"No." He stood at the edge of the ash. Looking into nothing. "I've never had a reason."

"And now?"

"Now I have completion."

He stepped forward. Into the void.

I expected him to fall. To disappear. To scream.

Instead: silence.

He just stepped out of the pattern. Out of the gray. Out of the ash.

I couldn't see him anymore. But I could hear him.

"It's not nothing," his voice said. From everywhere and nowhere. "It's... outside."

"Cole?"

"Come see, Kael. Before you can't."

I looked at the void. The absence. The place the pattern didn't reach.

I thought about the ledger. The Vesting Line. The record we were creating.

I thought about the 931 years. The generations. The infinite loop.

Then I stepped forward.

Into completion.

The machine kept running.

But I didn't.

To be continued in Book 3: Zero Clearance